

What 232 real positions actually say

A post-mortem on a personal Polymarket US trading record — including the two findings that contradict what the trader believed was true.

516 ledger rows 232 positions \$12,615 deployed 7 months NFL · NBA · CBB · NHL

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01 The bottom line

REALIZED ACCOUNT P&L +\$231.76 Cash in vs. cash out. Cannot be misread.	RETURN ON DEPOSITS +167.3% \$138.54 in, \$350 withdrawn, \$20.30 held.	ROI PER DOLLAR WAGERED +6.9% 95% CI [−3.5%, +17.8%] — spans zero.
PROFIT FROM TWO POSITIONS 69% Both on the Seattle Seahawks.		

The account made money. It has not demonstrated an edge. Those are different claims, and the gap between them is the subject of this note.

02 Two accounting facts that invert the answer

Neither is documented. Both were established by reconciling the ledger against itself, and each one flips a conclusion.

FINDING - WON ROWS

The amount is a **share count**, not dollar profit. Winning shares settle at \$1, so payout *is* the share count — which is why every such value is a whole number, and why **cost / payout** recovers the average entry price. It is the only route to entry prices in this export.

FINDING - LOST ROWS

A cost-basis write-off, **not a cash movement**. The money already left on the **Bought** row. Summing every **cash_flow** therefore double-counts every loss and reports this account as **-\$1,331** instead of **+\$643**. Verified on 42 of 75 losing positions to the cent; the exceptions are partial exits and rows whose buys predate the export.

Method. 33 positions were still open at export and are excluded from ROI rather than assumed lost. Marking them to zero would swing resolved P&L from **+\$866** to **-\$717**, so the choice is not cosmetic.

03 By sport PRIOR REFUTED

The belief going in was that college basketball was the most profitable segment. It was the least.

SPORT	POS	WIN%	DEPLOYED	P&L	ROI	95% CI ON ROI
NFL	11	91%	\$694	+\$697	+100.4%	
NBA	47	62%	\$6,140	+\$300	+4.9%	
CBB	126	59%	\$4,772	-\$124	-2.6%	
All	185	62%	\$12,615	+\$866	+6.9%	

 excludes zero  spans zero - no edge established scale -40% ... +170%

College basketball was the largest sample — 126 of 185 positions — which makes it the least likely of these figures to be noise, and it lost money.

NFL's +100% is not a finding. Eleven positions, 57% of the profit in a single bet. The interval is wide because the sample is tiny.

Classification required exact full team names. Matching on mascot alone files *Eastern Washington Eagles* under Philadelphia and *Eastern Illinois Panthers* under Carolina — contaminating an 11-position pro sample with college results and moving its ROI by more than 50 points before the bug was caught.

04 Concentration

CONFIRMED

Two Seattle Seahawks positions produced \$599 of \$866 in resolved profit. A single position accounts for 46% of everything. Remove those two and the entire record returns +2.4% rather than +6.9%.

This is the dominant risk fact about the account: the headline return is one outcome away from flat.

05 The conviction hypothesis

NOT ESTABLISHED

Stake size is chosen *before* the outcome is known, which makes it a legitimate ex-ante variable rather than a hindsight artifact. Sorting resolved positions into stake quartiles:

QUARTILE	N	AVG BET	WIN%	ROI	IMPLIED ENTRY PX	EDGE VS. PRICE
Smallest	46	\$4.77	52%	-18.9%	0.643	-12.2 pts
2nd	46	\$10.88	57%	-9.1%	0.622	-5.6 pts
3rd	46	\$31.79	54%	-19.8%	0.678	-13.4 pts
Largest	47	\$221.98	83%	+11.9%	0.741	+8.8 pts

Implied entry price solves $ROI = \text{winrate} / \text{price} - 1$, which separates *won often* from *beat the price* — a high win rate on heavy favorites is expected and carries no edge. The largest quartile beat its own entry price by roughly nine points; every other quartile lost to it.



WHY THIS IS REPORTED AS A HYPOTHESIS

Removing every Seahawks position drops the gap to +19.2 points with a CI of [-0.9, +39.2] — **spanning zero**. The direction survives; the significance does not. Add that this is one split among several examined (sport, hold-vs-sell, stake size), and a single robustness check that flips the conclusion is not an established effect.

Verdict: worth testing forward, not a result. It is stated here with its failure mode attached rather than as the headline it superficially resembles.

06 What this dataset cannot answer

- **The halftime rule** — *a team up 10+ at half wins ~80%, so buy below 0.80* — is untestable here. No timestamps finer than "6mo ago", no scores, no in-play markers. The premise is sound, but the market prices it too; the edge exists only if the market updates slower than the rule, and the negative CBB result is what the absence of that lag looks like.
- **Calibration.** Entry price is recoverable only on winners, because losers pay zero and reveal no share count. The 0.747 median entry is a biased sample and no reliability curve can be built from it.
- **Closing line value**, the fastest-converging edge measure, needs prices captured before each event closed. That data was never recorded — the single largest gap in the dataset.

07 Conclusions

- Profitable in cash terms; per-dollar edge statistically indistinguishable from zero.
- The strongest prior belief is contradicted by the largest sample in the dataset.
- Returns are dangerously concentrated — 69% of profit from two positions.
- Small stakes were systematically unprofitable: -12 points against price in the bottom quartile, across many positions.
- Conviction sizing is the one live hypothesis, and it is not yet significant.

ACTIONABLE IMPLICATION

The consistent loser is the small-stake tail — a behavioral finding with a direct control: stop taking marginal positions. The live scanner implements this as a raised edge threshold and a concentrated position cap, fixed in advance so that forward results test the hypothesis rather than fit it.

Forward validation, not further slicing of these 185 positions, settles any of it.

All figures reproducible via `python analyze_history.py <export>.csv --balance <bal>`. Confidence intervals are percentile bootstraps, 10,000 resamples.